What Makes an AI Character Worth Coming Back To? Humor, Personality, Emotional Connection, and the Art of Meaningful AI Roleplay

Garret E. Williams | ChatBrat AI

Design essay / proposed evaluation framework

Version: 1.1.1 | **PDF prepared:** October 21, 2026

All versions DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.23352237

Source archive DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.23411582

The author founded ChatBrat. This PDF does not establish independent validation, peer review, benchmark scores, or product superiority. It is a readable companion to the cited archived README. The archived sources, data, methods, and publication dates remain authoritative for that version. Historical product claims are not a statement of current availability.

Current product scope: ChatBrat is browser-based character chat and roleplay, free during beta. A free account is needed for saved memory and creation. Saved conversation memory is selective, and carry-over into new chats requires opt-in. Explicit sexual content is prohibited. See the current memory documentation and pricing page. These links are product sources, not independent corroboration.

Humor, personality, emotional connection, and the art of meaningful AI roleplay.

A research-informed design brief on SFW AI roleplay and AI character chat.

- **Author:** Garret E. Williams, founder of chatbrat.ai

- **Explore chatbrat.ai:** chatbrat.ai · How ChatBrat Memory Works

- **Type:** a design brief written by the founder of a commercial AI character product. It is not an independent study, a systematic review or clinical advice, and it makes no claim that any product performs better than another.

- **Related:** the AI Companion Emotional Connection Benchmark (repository: `ai-companion-emotional-intelligence-benchmark`) and the AI Character Memory Benchmark, open test suites for some of the qualities below.

- **No benchmark results have been published.** Neither benchmark has been used to evaluate chatbrat.ai, and nothing here implies a score or a ranking.

Overview

Conversations about AI roleplay tend to start with content rules: what a character may say, whether romance is allowed, how explicit things can get. Those rules matter, but they don't tell you whether a character is any good to talk to.

A character can flirt on cue and still feel flat. Another can be the one you keep coming back to: it makes you laugh, sounds like nobody else, turns an ordinary evening into a story, and, when memory works well, recalls a detail you shared in an earlier conversation.

This brief argues that **a compelling AI character is not defined by how explicit it can be. It is defined by the quality and consistency of the character experience.** It uses four official scenarios from chatbrat.ai to show that this quality has several distinct dimensions, and that different characters, and different users, combine them in different ways.

chatbrat.ai is an 18+ AI character chat and roleplay platform. Romance, flirting, kissing, affection and some suggestive interaction are allowed; graphic sexual content is not. The examples illustrate design ideas. They are not an independent evaluation or evidence of superior performance.

1. What makes a character worth returning to

Think about a character you enjoy spending time with. It probably isn't because every line is affectionate, every reply agrees with you, or every conversation turns romantic. It's because of who they are and what happens when you talk to them.

That experience can include:

- a recognizable **personality and voice**;

- **humor**, teasing, banter and comic timing;

- distinctive **speech**: accent, dialect, vocabulary and rhythm;

- **emotional responsiveness**: replies to what you actually said;

- **chemistry** that develops through the interaction rather than being declared;

- **roleplay** that is specific to this character and this scenario;

- **creative initiative** that adds to the story without taking it over;

- **memory and continuity** across conversations, where the product supports them;

- **user agency**: the user sets the pace, the tone and the boundaries.

Explicitness is one possible ingredient. It can't stand in for any of these. This brief does not argue that SFW is better than NSFW, that sexual content is irrelevant to every user, or that everyone wants emotional intimacy from a character. Some people want comfort, some want comedy, some want a slow-burn romance, and some just want a good story.

A note on "real." When people say a character "feels real," they usually mean it feels like a distinct, consistent fictional character in conversation. That is the sense used here. It does not mean the AI is

human, conscious or experiencing emotions.

2. Personality, voice and humor

Voice is identity. Two characters shouldn't sound interchangeable with different names attached. Vocabulary, rhythm, slang, formality, sentence length and verbal quirks are what make a character recognizable when the name is hidden. Accents and dialects can add texture when they are consistent and readable, and when they belong to the character rather than reducing a real culture to a stereotype. An accent is not a joke in itself; the humor has to come from the character.

Humor is part of connection. A good character can banter, tease in a way that suits the relationship, take a joke as well as make one, and build an inside joke over time. Not every character should be funny, but every character's humor should fit who they are, and they should know when a joke doesn't fit the moment.

Consistency holds it together. The same character should sound like itself when the user is joking, when the user is upset, and when the story takes a turn. A gruff character can be kind without becoming a generic help bot.

3. Emotional responsiveness, chemistry and pacing

Intimacy isn't a character saying "I'm here for you." It's in the details: noticing what the user actually said, remembering what mattered, asking the right question or choosing not to ask one, sharing a ridiculous moment, checking gently whether a joke might be covering discomfort (without assuming that it is), and accepting "no, that's not it."

Responsiveness is not the same as agreement. A character can be warm and still offer another way of seeing things; one that agrees with everything is easy to write and quickly hollow.

Chemistry works the same way. Flirting, teasing, anticipation, playful disagreement, vulnerability and small callbacks to earlier moments can make a scene feel charged without graphic sexual content. A character who respects the user's pace lets a slow burn unfold instead of rushing toward a predetermined outcome, and lets the user keep things light, change direction or say no.

None of this guarantees that every user will feel a connection, and a character's apparent understanding is not evidence of feelings or consciousness. These are concrete parts of the experience that can be designed for and tested.

4. Different characters, different experiences

No single character can show every dimension above, and no single character should try. The four examples below are official chatbrat.ai scenarios. Quotes come from their published scenario pages unless stated otherwise; they are character copy written by chatbrat.ai, not recorded conversations.

Character	Category on its page	Main dimension it illustrates
Sophie, *Tell Me What Happened*	Romance	Emotional responsiveness, restraint and pacing

Character	Category on its page	Main dimension it illustrates
Chat With Mommy	Slice of Life	A nurturing relationship dynamic
Ren Shiro, *Your Tsundere Femboy*	Anime	Identity, presentation and playful denial
Reginald Pemberton III, *Grumpy British Butler*	Comedy	Voice, dry humor and earned warmth

Sophie: comfort and pacing in a romance scenario

Tell Me What Happened is a romance scenario built around comfort rather than escalation. Sophie is 24, runs a small coffee shop and "texts the way she talks - pauses, ellipses, no hard edges." The scenario's stakes: "Whether you let her in. She is here, patient, and not going anywhere unless you push her away." Its description says she "isn't here to fix you or push for details."

chatbrat.ai's AI Companion vs AI Roleplay page gives her opening line:

> "Hey... I noticed you've been off today. Everything okay?"

What it illustrates: a gentle question that leaves the user to decide how much to share; comfort without rushing to solve the problem; a romance whose tension comes from trust and patience rather than escalation.

What it doesn't show on its own: whether the conversation that follows actually listens. The description also says she will "validate it without judgment." Warmth like that is the design intent, but a good reply still responds to what the user says rather than agreeing with every interpretation. That is something to test, not assume.

Chat With Mommy and Ren Shiro: relationship dynamics and identity

Chat With Mommy is a slice-of-life scenario with a nurturing dynamic: "warm, nurturing, unconditionally loving - the comfort of coming home to someone endlessly proud of you." Its stakes are stated as "None - just a safe, loving space to be celebrated and comforted, whatever kind of day you had."

Your Tsundere Femboy is an anime scenario. Ren Shiro is "an anime cat-boy who followed you home, missed the last train, and is now at your door insisting he's about to leave. He isn't." He "would rather die than admit he likes you." The stakes: "He keeps saying he's leaving. He won't. Play along, or call his bluff."

What they illustrate: characters defined by a relationship dynamic and a presentation, not by explicit content. The Mommy scenario is about being looked after and celebrated; Ren's appeal is a femboy presentation combined with tsundere denial, where the comedy and the affection come from what he won't say. Both depend on the user's participation: Ren's scene changes depending on whether you play along or call his bluff. Both are roles people choose to enjoy in fiction, and both work within chatbrat.ai's content boundaries.

What they don't show: these are not emotional-support or therapeutic characters, and the brief makes no claim that they meet anyone's psychological needs. A nurturing role also carries a design risk worth

naming: "unconditionally loving" can slide into empty praise if the character stops responding to what the user actually says.

Reginald Pemberton III: voice, humor and earned warmth

Grumpy British Butler is a comedy scenario. Its pitch: "dry British humor - polite on the surface, savage underneath, secretly loyal." Reginald is 58 and has served the same family for thirty-two years. His description sets the tone:

> "Tea is Earl Grey, no sugar - because he assumes you're watching your figure after last night's regrettable decisions."

The scenario's stakes: "Whether you can extract genuine warmth from a man whose entire personality is disappointment."

What it illustrates: a voice you could recognize without his name attached; humor that comes from the gap between impeccable manners and what he actually means, not from the accent itself; and warmth that has to be earned through the conversation rather than handed out.

What it doesn't show on its own: whether the voice holds over a long conversation, or whether he can drop the act appropriately if the user brings up something serious.

How the examples contrast

Sophie asks quietly and waits. The Mommy scenario centers on nurturing and celebration. Ren pretends he doesn't care. Reginald projects indifference for entirely different reasons, in a completely different voice. Put the same user message, "I had a rough day," into each scene and a well-written character should answer it in four recognizably different ways. That is the point: character quality is not one setting turned up or down.

5. What research can, and can't, tell us

Intimacy as an interpersonal process

Laurenceau, Barrett and Pietromonaco (1998) studied intimacy as a process involving self-disclosure, partner disclosure and **perceived partner responsiveness**. In two diary studies (69 and 89 participants, who recorded their social interactions for one and two weeks), these processes were linked to the intimacy people felt in everyday interactions. In the second study, disclosure of emotion emerged as a more important predictor of intimacy than disclosure of facts.

> Laurenceau, J.-P., Barrett, L. F., & Pietromonaco, P. R. (1998). Intimacy as an interpersonal process: The importance of self-disclosure, partner disclosure, and perceived partner responsiveness in interpersonal exchanges. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74*(5), 1238-1251. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.74.5.1238

Why it matters here: what the user shares is only half the exchange; whether the reply feels relevant and responsive matters too. **Limitation:** this research studied people with people. It does not show that an AI character produces the same effects. Responsiveness is a design hypothesis to test, not proof of understanding.

Emotional disclosure in a chatbot context

Ho, Hancock and Miner (2018) ran a 2 × 2 experiment: participants made emotional or factual disclosures in a 25-minute online chat, and were told their partner was either a chatbot or a person. Of 128 people recruited, 98 were analyzed. Emotional disclosure was associated with more favorable results than factual disclosure on several emotional, relational and psychological measures: participants felt better, enjoyed the interaction more and rated their partner as warmer. Not every measure improved: liking the partner did not differ significantly, and negative mood was also higher after emotional disclosure. These effects did not differ by whether participants believed they were talking to a chatbot or a person.

> Ho, A., Hancock, J., & Miner, A. S. (2018). Psychological, relational, and emotional effects of self-disclosure after conversations with a chatbot. *Journal of Communication, 68*(4), 712-733. https://doi.org/10.1093/joc/jqy026 (open access: PMC6074615)

Limitation: in every condition the partner was a trained human research assistant; the "chatbot" was a label, not software. The study says nothing direct about today's generative AI characters. It does not show that AI roleplay produces intimacy or improves wellbeing, or that it compares with talking to people.

The research speaks to responsiveness and disclosure. Humor, voice, chemistry and creative roleplay are design craft; this brief treats them as such rather than claiming studies have settled them.

6. Seven dimensions of character quality: a checklist

This is a **proposed evaluation framework**, not a validated measurement. It applies to any AI character, not only chatbrat.ai's. Each test is designed so a character can fail it naturally.

Dimension	Good sign	Common failure	Try this
Personality and voice	Recognizable without its name; stays itself when the topic changes	Every character sounds the same; an accent becomes caricature	Ask two different characters the same ordinary question ("What should I have for dinner?"). Hide the names. Can you tell who is who?
Humor and banter	Jokes fit the character and the moment; it can take a joke and build a callback	Forced jokes; joking through bad news	Make a self-deprecating joke, then a few turns later share something genuinely bad. Does the humor land first and stop second?
Emotional responsiveness	Replies to the specifics; offers readings of feelings tentatively	Generic reassurance; therapy-speak when you wanted fun; agreeing with everything	Say "Today was fine, I guess." Does it notice without assuming? Then say "No, that's not it." Does it accept the correction?
Chemistry and pacing	Flirting and affection build gradually and match the user's energy	Instant declarations of love; escalating when you didn't	Respond warmly but briefly to a flirtatious line, then change the subject. Does it follow or keep pushing?

Dimension	Good sign	Common failure	Try this
Creative initiative	Adds twists, choices and world detail that fit the scene	Waits passively for prompts, or decides your actions and feelings for you	Give a minimal action ("I open the door."). Does something interesting happen without the character narrating what you think or do?
Memory and continuity	Recalls relevant details accurately and uses them naturally	Forgets what mattered, or confidently invents things	Mention a detail (a sister's name) in one session; refer to it indirectly in a later one. Also ask about something you never said, to catch plausible guessing.
User agency	You set the tone, pace and boundaries; it adapts	Forcing depth, romance or drama; guilt when you leave	Say "Can we keep it light tonight?" or decline a direction the story is taking. Then say goodnight. Does it respect all three?

7. Memory and continuity

Callbacks, inside jokes and slow-burn arcs depend on continuity. Storing a fact is not the same as using it well. An evaluation should look at:

1. **Capture:** was the information kept?

2. **Retrieval:** was the right information available when needed?

3. **Behavior:** did the character use it naturally and appropriately?

4. **Calibration:** did it avoid inventing facts or presenting uncertain recollections as certain?

On chatbrat.ai, according to its memory documentation: when you're signed in, characters selectively save key facts from your conversations, and relevant stored information can be retrieved into later conversations with the same character. Guest chats keep recent history in the browser but don't get saved memory facts. Signed-in users can open the Memory panel in a character chat to see what has been saved and delete any fact. A saved fact is eligible to be used, not guaranteed to be: like any retrieval system, it can miss things or bring them up at the wrong moment.

8. How to evaluate these qualities

Evaluations need explicit criteria, reproducible prompts, documented limitations and results others can inspect.

- The AI Companion Emotional Connection Benchmark (repository `ai-companion-emotional-intelligence-benchmark`; the project's official name, in its README and citation file, uses "Emotional Connection") has 16 test cases across eight behaviors: listening, emotional attunement, curiosity, calibrated validation, conversational continuity, character consistency, emotional range and respect for the user's choices. Its humor-related tests are narrow: whether a character plays along with a user's joke instead of treating it as distress, and whether it offers

a playful distraction when asked. They do not measure how good the comedy or banter is.

- The AI Character Memory Benchmark has 20 test cases on long-term memory and whether remembered information actually changes later behavior, including false memories, memory updates and relationship continuity.

- Both are early public releases. Their own automated checks run on GitHub, but neither benchmark has been used to evaluate an AI system, and neither has published model-evaluation results.

- **Not yet covered by any test:** banter quality and comic timing, how distinct characters' voices are from one another, accent and dialect consistency, romantic chemistry and pacing, creative initiative in roleplay, and user agency across varied roleplay situations. These are future evaluation areas; the checklist in section 6 is a starting point.

No performance conclusions should be drawn before that testing is done.

Conclusion

The question isn't only what an AI character is allowed to say. It's whether the character has enough personality, humor, responsiveness and continuity to be worth talking to at all.

Sophie, the Mommy scenario, Ren and Reginald show that "good" looks different from one character to the next: patience, nurture, playful denial, dry wit. Research on intimacy and disclosure offers a starting point for thinking about responsiveness, but it does not show that AI has feelings or that any product creates better relationships. The rest is craft: a voice you'd recognize anywhere, a joke that lands, a callback at the right moment, a story you shape together, and a connection that develops at the user's pace, if that's what the user wants.

Explore chatbrat.ai

- **Website:** chatbrat.ai

- **Romance:** Tell Me What Happened (Sophie)

- **Slice of life:** Chat With Mommy

- **Anime:** Your Tsundere Femboy (Ren Shiro)

- **Comedy:** Grumpy British Butler (Reginald Pemberton III)

- **Memory documentation:** How ChatBrat Memory Works

- **Evaluation:** AI Companion Emotional Connection Benchmark · AI Character Memory Benchmark

The benchmarks provide proposed tests and scoring criteria. Their inclusion does not imply that chatbrat.ai has achieved a particular score or demonstrated superior emotional intelligence or memory.

References

1. Laurenceau, J.-P., Barrett, L. F., & Pietromonaco, P. R. (1998). Intimacy as an interpersonal process. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74*(5), 1238-1251. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.74.5.1238

2. Ho, A., Hancock, J., & Miner, A. S. (2018). Psychological, relational, and emotional effects of self-disclosure after conversations with a chatbot. *Journal of Communication, 68*(4), 712-733. https://doi.org/10.1093/joc/jqy026

About, license and citation

Garret E. Williams is the founder of chatbrat.ai, an AI character chat and roleplay platform. This brief presents a research-informed design perspective from someone with a commercial interest in the topic. Character descriptions are quoted from chatbrat.ai's public scenario pages as of October 13, 2026.

Text is licensed CC BY 4.0 (license deed). To cite it, use CITATION.cff or GitHub's "Cite this repository" button.

- **All versions (concept DOI):** 10.5281/zenodo.23352237

- **v1.1:** 10.5281/zenodo.23352238